490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 12 OF 26

Wilderness and Conquest

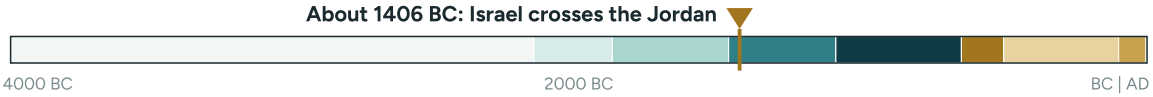
Numbers 13–14; Deuteronomy 6–8; Joshua 1–6



David S. Jones

October 18, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 12



Introduction: An Eleven-Day Trip That Took Forty Years

Deuteronomy opens with a detail that is easy to read past: "It is eleven days' journey from Horeb by the way of Mount Seir to Kadesh-barnea" (Deut. 1:2). Horeb is Mount Sinai. Kadesh-barnea sits on the southern edge of the land God promised to Abraham. From the mountain where God gave his law to the doorstep of the Promised Land was less than two weeks on foot.

It took Israel forty years.

This lesson covers that whole stretch of the story, the books of Numbers, Deuteronomy, and Joshua. It is a story of failure and faithfulness: a people who refused to trust God at the border, a generation that died in the desert, a God who carried them anyway, and a new leader who finally brought them in. On our timeline it runs from about 1445 BC, when Israel left Sinai, to about 1406 BC, when they crossed the Jordan River, and on through Joshua's last years. And it is full of pictures of Jesus, who walked into the wilderness himself and came out with the victory Israel never won.

The Word: Joshua

> **Numbers 13:16** *"These were the names of the men whom Moses sent to spy out the land. And Moses called Hoshea the son of Nun, Joshua."*

יְהוֹשֻׁעַ *(Yehoshua, "Joshua")*

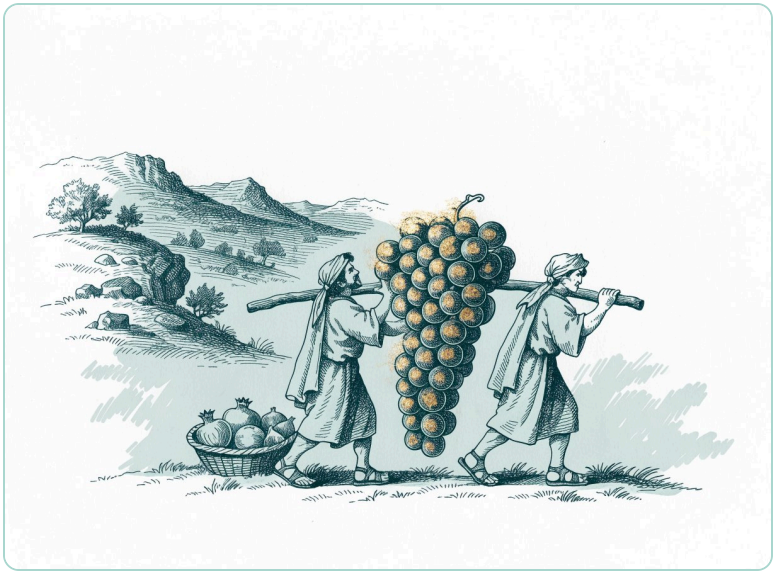
"the LORD saves" or "the LORD is salvation"

יְהוֹ (Yeho)	+	יָשַׁע (yasha)
"the LORD"		*"to save, rescue"*
A short form of God's personal name, the name he revealed at the burning bush.		Moses' assistant was born Hoshea, "salvation." Moses added God's name to it.

Payoff: In Greek, Joshua's name is *Iēsous*. In English, that is *Jesus*. When the angel told Joseph, "you shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins" (Matt. 1:21), he was giving Mary's son the name of the man who led Israel into the Promised Land. The first Joshua led God's people across the Jordan. The second Joshua leads them home.

Part One: Failure at the Border

When Israel reached Kadesh, Moses sent twelve men, one from each tribe, to scout the land. They came back after forty days with proof that God had told the truth. In the Valley of Eshcol they had cut "a branch with a single cluster of grapes, and they carried it on a pole between two of them" (Num. 13:23). The land really did flow with milk and honey.



They "cut down from there a branch with a single cluster of grapes, and they carried it on a pole between two of them" (Num. 13:23).

But ten of the twelve spies could not stop talking about the walls and the warriors. "However, the people who dwell in the land are strong, and the cities are fortified and very large" (13:28). Fear spread through the camp like fire. That night the people wept and said, "Would that we had died in the land of Egypt! Or would that we had died in this wilderness!... Let us choose a leader and go back to Egypt" (14:2, 4). The people God had carried out of slavery on eagles' wings now wanted to go back to the whips.

Only two men stood against the crowd: Joshua and Caleb. "If the LORD delights in us, he will bring us into this land and give it to us, a land that flows with milk and honey. Only do not rebel against the LORD. And do not fear the people of the land" (14:8–9). They saw the same walls as everyone else. The difference was that they also saw God.

God forgave the people when Moses prayed for them (14:20), but forgiveness did not erase the consequences. The generation that refused to go in would not go in. "According to the number of the days in which you spied out the land, forty days, a year for each day, you shall bear your iniquity forty years" (14:34). Only Caleb and Joshua from that generation would enter the land, because Caleb "has a different spirit and has followed me fully" (14:24). Hebrews puts its finger on the root of it: "they were unable to enter because of unbelief" (Heb. 3:19).

Part Two: Forty Years in the Desert

What happened during those forty years? Mostly, the old generation slowly died, and a new one grew up. But this was not a story of God walking away. Years later, Moses looked back and told the new generation what God had been doing the whole time:

> **Deuteronomy 8:2–4** *"And you shall remember the whole way that the LORD your God has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you, testing you to know what was in your heart, whether you would keep his commandments or not. And he humbled you and let you hunger and fed you with manna, which you did not know, nor did your fathers know, that he might make you know that man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD. Your clothing did not wear out on you and your foot did not swell these forty years."*

Six mornings a week for forty years, bread from heaven lay on the ground (Ex. 16:26, 35). Their sandals never wore out (Deut. 29:5). The cloud led them by day and the fire by night. Moses said God had carried them "as a man carries his son, all the way that you went" (Deut. 1:31). The wilderness was discipline, but it was a Father's discipline (8:5).

Even Moses failed in the wilderness. When the people complained about water, God told Moses to speak to a rock. Instead, in anger, Moses struck it twice and said, "Hear now, you rebels: shall we bring water for you out of this rock?" (Num. 20:10). God gave the water anyway, but he told Moses that because he had not trusted God and honored him as holy in front of the people, Moses would not lead Israel into the land (20:12). If the greatest leader in Israel's history could not get himself into the Promised Land, no one would get in on their own record.

Then came one of the strangest scenes in the Old Testament. The people grumbled again, and "the LORD sent fiery serpents among the people, and they bit the people, so that many people of Israel died" (21:6). When the people confessed their sin, God told Moses to make a bronze serpent and put it on a pole. "And if a serpent bit anyone, he would look at the bronze serpent and live" (21:9). No medicine. No work. Just a look of trust at the thing God had lifted up.



"If a serpent bit anyone, he would look at the bronze serpent and live" (Num. 21:9).

Fourteen centuries later, Jesus told a religious leader named Nicodemus what that scene was about: "And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life" (John 3:14–15). The cure for the bite of sin is to look in faith at the One lifted up on the cross.

CORE DOCTRINE 12 OF 26

Saving Faith

Faith is trusting God's promise and resting on Christ alone for salvation. Israel saw God's miracles in the wilderness, yet they could not enter the land because of unbelief. Faith is leaning our whole weight on what God has said. It is not a work that earns anything.

KEY VERSES

Numbers 14:11; Hebrews 3:19; 11:6; John 3:16

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"Faith in Jesus Christ is a saving grace, whereby we receive and rest upon him alone for salvation, as he is offered to us in the gospel." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 86)

WHY IT MATTERS

Faith is only as good as the One you trust. Weak faith in a strong Savior saves.

Part Three: Moses' Last Sermons

Forty years after the exodus, Israel camped on the plains of Moab, just east of the Jordan River, across from the city of Jericho. The old generation was gone. Before he died, Moses preached a series of farewell sermons to their children. Those sermons are the book of Deuteronomy, a Greek name meaning "second law." It fits, because Moses was retelling God's law to a new generation.

At the heart of Deuteronomy is a confession that observant Jews still recite every morning and evening, called the Shema after its first word, "Hear":

> **Deuteronomy 6:4–7** *"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might. And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."*

When someone asked Jesus which commandment was the greatest, he quoted this passage (Matt. 22:37–38). Moses wanted God's words at the kitchen table, on the road, and in the last words spoken before sleep.

Moses also made sure the new generation understood why God had chosen them. "It was not because you were more in number than any other people that the LORD set his love on you and chose you, for you were the fewest of all peoples, but it is because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers" (Deut. 7:7–8). And they were not about to receive the land because they were better than the Canaanites: "the LORD your God is not giving you this good land to possess because of your righteousness, for you are a stubborn people" (9:6). It was grace from start to finish.

Moses knew their hearts would keep failing. So near the end he gave them a promise: "And the LORD your God will circumcise your heart and the heart of your offspring, so that you will love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul, that you may live" (30:6). The law could command love. Only God could create it. God was already giving new hearts to people like Caleb and Rahab. But the promise points ahead to the new covenant, when Christ would pour out his Spirit in fullness (Jer. 31:33; Ezek. 36:26).

Then Moses climbed Mount Nebo. From the top "the LORD showed him all the land," as far as the western sea, down to "the Valley of Jericho the city of palm trees" (34:1, 3). God said, "I have let you see it with your eyes, but you shall not go over there" (34:4). And Moses died on the mountain, and God himself buried him (34:5–6). Like Abraham and his sons before him, the greatest prophet in Israel saw the promise from a distance and died in faith (see Heb. 11:13). Centuries later he would stand on another mountain, in the land at last, talking with Jesus (Matt. 17:3).

Part Four: Into the Land

After Moses died, God spoke to Joshua: "Just as I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not leave you or forsake you. Be strong and courageous" (Josh. 1:5–6). Joshua's courage would rest on God's presence and God's word, which he was to meditate on "day and night" (1:8).

Rahab. The first person in Canaan we meet is a prostitute in Jericho named Rahab. She hid two Israelite spies and told them why: "I know that the LORD has given you the land.... for the LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath" (2:9, 11). She had heard what God did at the Red Sea forty years earlier, and she believed. She tied a scarlet cord in her window as a sign, and when the city fell, she and her family were saved (6:25). Hebrews lists her among the heroes of faith (Heb. 11:31). And Matthew lists her in the family tree of Jesus (Matt. 1:5). A Canaanite woman with a ruined reputation became an ancestor of the Messiah. Grace was never limited to one bloodline.

The Jordan. When the priests carrying the ark stepped into the river, "the waters coming down from above stood and rose up in a heap very far away," and "all Israel was passing over on dry ground" (3:16–17). A generation that had been children at the Red Sea, or not yet born, now walked through a river of their own. Joshua had twelve stones taken from the riverbed and stacked as a memorial, so that "when your children ask in time to come, 'What do those stones mean to you?'" the parents could tell them what God had done (4:6–7).

Jericho. Before the battle, Joshua met a man with a drawn sword and asked, "Are you for us, or for our adversaries?" The answer: "No; but I am the commander of the army of the LORD" (5:13–14). Joshua fell on his face and took off his sandals, because the ground was holy (5:14–15). Many Christians have seen in this commander the Son of God himself, come to lead the battle. Jericho fell without a battering ram or a single assault on its walls. The people marched around it for seven days, the priests blew rams' horns, the people shouted, "and the wall fell down flat" (6:20). "By faith the walls of Jericho fell down" (Heb. 11:30).

Years of fighting followed. When the land had been divided among the tribes, the book sums up God's faithfulness in one of the great sentences of the Bible: "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass" (21:45). The promise God made to Abraham in Genesis 12, that his offspring would receive this land, had come true. God had kept every word. Whether Israel would finish the job is the question Lesson 13 will answer. Before he died, the old Joshua gathered the people and put the choice to them: "choose this day whom you will serve.... But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD" (24:15).

From Sinai to the Promised Land

Dates follow 1 Kings 6:1 (the early date); all are approximate

1445 BC	**Leave Sinai**	*Num. 10:11*
1445 BC	**Spies at Kadesh; people refuse**	*Num. 13–14*
1445–1406	**Thirty-eight more years in the wilderness**	*Num. 14:33–34*
1406 BC	**Plains of Moab: Moses' last sermons**	*Deuteronomy*
1406 BC	**Moses dies on Mount Nebo**	*Deut. 34*
1406 BC	**Cross the Jordan; Jericho falls**	*Josh. 3–6*
about 1400	**Caleb, 85, receives Hebron**	*Josh. 14:6–15*
about 1380s	**Joshua: choose whom you will serve**	*Josh. 24*

"It is eleven days' journey from Horeb… to Kadesh-barnea" (Deut. 1:2). It took forty years.

The Hard Question: What About the Canaanites?

Any honest reader of Joshua stops at verses like this: "they devoted all in the city to destruction, both men and women, young and old" (6:21). How could a loving God command that? This is hard, and it should feel hard. Christians have thought carefully about it for centuries. Here is what the Bible itself says.

It was judgment, after long patience. Centuries earlier, God told Abraham his descendants would live as strangers in a foreign land for four hundred years before he brought them back, "for the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete" (Gen. 15:13, 16). God waited centuries. The Canaanite religions included burning children as offerings: "they even burn their sons and their daughters in the fire to their gods" (Deut. 12:31). God said the land itself "vomited out its inhabitants" (Lev. 18:25). This was not about race, and it was not a reward for Israel's goodness (Deut. 9:5–6). When Israel later did the same things, God drove them out of the land too, just as he had warned (Lev. 18:28; 2 Kings 17:7–18).

God is the Judge, and he takes no delight in death. To "devote to destruction" meant handing a city over wholly to God, as his judgment. That included children, and I will not pretend that is easy to read. But the Bible says every life belongs to the God who gave it, and that "the wages of sin is death" for every one of us (Rom. 6:23). God does not hand out death lightly: "I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked" (Ezek. 33:11). We are not told everything. We are told enough to trust that "all his ways are justice" (Deut. 32:4).

Mercy was open. Rahab heard the same news as everyone else in Jericho and turned to God. She and her family were spared. Even the Gibeonites, who tricked their way into a treaty, were spared, and God held Israel to its oath (Josh. 9). God says elsewhere that when a nation under judgment "turns from its evil, I will relent" (Jer. 18:8).

It was a one-time command, not a pattern for us. God gave this command to Israel, by his direct word, for the conquest of one land in one period of history. He never gives it to the church. Jesus said, "My kingdom is not of this world. If my kingdom were of this world, my servants would have been fighting" (John 18:36). Christians spread the kingdom with the gospel, never the sword. Anyone who uses Joshua to justify violence today has misread the whole Bible.

It is a preview of the final judgment. One day God "will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed" (Acts 17:31). The conquest is a small, sobering picture of that day. And the only safe place then is the same as it was for Rahab: under the sign of God's mercy. For us that sign is the cross, where Jesus took the judgment we deserve.

THREAD WATCH

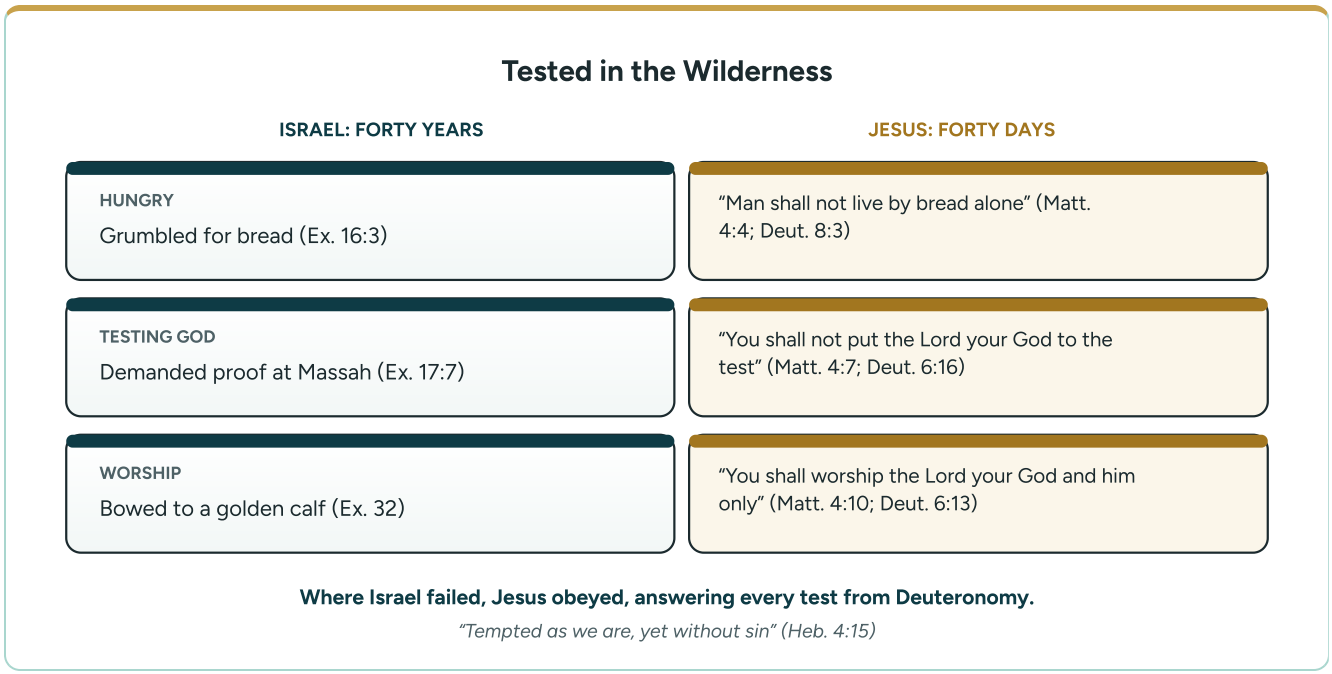
THE LAMB The thread runs through Rahab's house. In Egypt, blood on the door marked the homes God would pass over (Lesson 8). In Jericho, a scarlet cord in the window marked the one house that would be spared. Inside that house a whole family was safe. Their goodness had nothing to do with it. They were under the sign God's people had sworn to honor.

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The ark of God's presence went into the Jordan first, and the people followed it through on dry ground. And at last God gave them "rest on every side" (Josh. 21:44). For the first time since Eden, God's people were at rest in the place God had given them, with God dwelling among them. But Hebrews says that rest was not yet the final one: "if Joshua had given them rest, God would not have spoken of another day later on" (Heb. 4:8).

The Turn: The Better Joshua

About fourteen hundred years later, another Joshua came to the Jordan. Jesus was baptized in the same river Israel had crossed, and then "Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led by the Spirit in the wilderness for forty days, being tempted by the devil" (Luke 4:1–2). Forty days, for Israel's forty years. A different desert, the same tests.

Israel was hungry in the wilderness and grumbled. Jesus was hungry, and when the devil told him to turn stones into bread, he answered from Deuteronomy: "Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God" (Matt. 4:4; Deut. 8:3). Israel put God to the test at Massah. Jesus refused: "You shall not put the Lord your God to the test" (Matt. 4:7; Deut. 6:16). Israel turned to a golden calf. Jesus answered, "You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve" (Matt. 4:10; Deut. 6:13). Every answer Jesus gave came from Moses' last sermons. Where Israel failed, Jesus obeyed, and he did it for us.



Look back over this lesson and you will find Jesus everywhere. He is the true bread from heaven (John 6:32–35). He is the rock that gave water in the desert (1 Cor. 10:4). He is the One lifted up like the bronze serpent, so that everyone who looks to him in faith will live (John 3:14–15). He is the better Joshua, who leads us past every border into God's own rest. "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28).

The saddest words in this lesson are "they were unable to enter because of unbelief." The ten spies saw the fruit with their own eyes and still would not trust God. Hebrews turns their story into an invitation for you: "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts" (Heb. 3:15). Do not stand at the border. Turn from your sin, trust the Savior who passed every test in your place, and follow him in.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1 **Read the border story.** Read Numbers 13–14. Notice what the ten spies saw and what Caleb and Joshua saw.

2 **Name your giants.** What fear is keeping you from trusting God right now? Write it down, and next to it write Numbers 14:8–9.

3 **Remember the manna.** List five ways God has provided for you this year that you did not earn or plan. Thank him for each one.

4 **Pray the Shema.** Read Deuteronomy 6:4–9 each morning. Pick one place in your daily routine to talk about God with your family or a friend.

5 **Build a memorial.** Like the twelve stones, tell someone this week one specific thing God has done for you.

6 **Memorize Joshua 1:9.** “Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.”

Before Lesson 13: *Read Judges 2:6–23 and the book of Ruth. Lesson 13 opens Unit 4: Israel in the land, falling into a cycle of sin and rescue, and a quiet love story that leads to a king.*

For Discussion

1. Kadesh was only an eleven-day walk from Sinai. Why do you think fear was more powerful than everything the people had already seen God do?
2. Caleb and Joshua saw the same giants as the other ten spies. What made the difference?
3. God forgave Israel but still let them face forty years of consequences. How do forgiveness and consequences fit together in your own life?
4. How does the bronze serpent help you understand what it means to believe in Jesus (John 3:14–15)?
5. Deuteronomy says God chose Israel because he loved them, not because they were better. Why does that matter for how you see yourself?
6. Rahab was a Canaanite and a prostitute, and she became an ancestor of Jesus. What does her story say to someone who thinks they are too far gone?
7. Jesus answered every temptation with Scripture. Which verse do you need ready for your own wilderness right now?
8. Which part of the Canaanite question is hardest for you? How does Rahab’s story change the way you see it?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the date of the exodus and conquest (about 1446 and 1406 BC), following 1 Kings 6:1: Eugene H. Merrill, *Kingdom of Priests*. Other evangelical scholars hold a later date in the 1200s BC.
- On the conquest and the Canaanites: Christopher J. H. Wright, *The God I Don’t Understand*; Meredith G. Kline, *The Structure of Biblical Authority* (on the “intrusion” of final judgment).
- For further reading: Dale Ralph Davis, *Joshua: No Falling Words*; Iain M. Duguid, *Numbers: God’s Presence in the Wilderness* (Preaching the Word); Daniel I. Block, *Deuteronomy* (NIV Application Commentary).



David S. Jones

Author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*. He teaches Scripture every week or so at 490.life, serves on the worship teams at Scottsdale Bible Church, and serves in the men’s group, The Forge, helping to disciple men and pointing them to Jesus. He coaches and mentors men one-to-one and speaks to churches and men’s groups.

© 2026 490 Life Publishing · David S. Jones · Scripture quotations from the ESV · 490.life